

Tea & Tech — Morning 4 Host Pack

Title for the poster: *Tea & Tech — Morning 4: Your Family History, with a Research Assistant* **Standing tagline:** *Pop in if you don't want to wait til the weekend.* **Length:** 90 minutes — though many learners will want to stay longer. Plan for it.

Assumes Mornings 1, 2, 3 are familiar.

What this morning is for

By the end of 90 minutes, every person in the room can:

1. **Tell Claude what they already know** — names, dates, parishes, places — and have it organised into something they can build on.
2. **Photograph an old record** — a baptism entry, a census page, a grave inscription — and have Claude transcribe and translate it.
3. **Know where to look next** — Irish Genealogy.ie, the National Archives, local parish records — without expecting Claude to do the searching for them.
4. **Start the family story** that grandchildren might actually read.

This is the morning that gives them a reason to keep using Claude *after* the course ends. Saturdays well spent.

Why this morning is different

The first three mornings were defensive — staying safe, understanding letters, getting things off the chest. **Morning 4 is the first time the learner is using Claude for something that's purely for them.** Curiosity, not necessity. The energy in the room is different — slower, more absorbed, more “show me yours and I'll show you mine.”

Plan accordingly:

- **The 1:30 lingering will run long.** Block 30 minutes, not 15. The genealogy conversations between attendees are themselves part of the morning.
 - **Bring printed examples.** A baptism entry in Latin, an 1851 census page, a Griffith's Valuation page. People who don't have records yet need something to practise on.
 - **Have the websites bookmarked on the spare phone.** Irish Genealogy.ie, the National Archives 1901/1911 census, the National Library parish registers. Some learners will want to go further the same morning.
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Timing

Time	What happens
0:00	Tea, scones, newcomers caught up
0:15	Welcome and the frame
0:25	What you already know — dictating a starting point
0:45	Reading old records — photo, transcribe, translate
1:05	Where to look next — Claude as research partner
1:15	Writing the story — turning notes into a page
1:25	Wrap and the awkward questions
1:30	Lingering (long)

The script

0:15 — Welcome and the frame (10 mins)

“Welcome back. This is the last morning of the four — though there’s no rule that says we can’t keep meeting if you’d like to.

*Today is the morning that’s just for you. The first three were about staying safe and getting things off your chest. Today is about **what you’d like to know**. Most of us in this room have wondered about a great-grandfather who emigrated, or a parish someone came from, or a grave we’ve never found. Today we make a start on it.*

*I want to say one thing up front. **Claude is not a genealogist**. It’s not a search engine for the records. What it’s brilliant at is helping you read what you find, organise what you know, and tell you where to look next. The looking is still your Saturday afternoon.”*

0:25 — What you already know (20 mins)

“Open Claude. Press the microphone. Tell it everything you already know about one branch of your family — a great-grandparent, a side that interests you. Names, dates, places, parishes, anything. It can be messy. It can be ‘I

think it was around 1880, my mother said it was Mayo but it might have been Galway.' Just talk."

Worked example, dictated by the host:

"My great-grandfather on my father's side was Patrick Walsh. I think he was born around 1865 in County Cork — somewhere near Bandon, my father said. He emigrated to Boston before the turn of the century, married a woman called Bridget Murphy from Clonakilty, and they had six children. He came back to visit once, in the 1920s. That's about all I know."

Then ask:

"Can you organise that into a starting family tree, with the gaps marked clearly so I know what to look for?"

Read Claude's answer aloud. **Notice the gaps.** Patrick's exact date of birth. The name of the parish. The ship he sailed on. The names of the six children.

*"See what it did. It didn't pretend to know things it doesn't. It marked the gaps. **Those gaps are your shopping list.** That's the homework."*

Let the room try with their own families. Rovers help. **The energy will pick up here — let it.**

0:45 — Reading old records (20 mins)

*"Now the trick that genuinely surprises people. Old records — baptism entries, census pages, gravestones — are often hard to read. Old handwriting. Latin. Faded ink. Photograph one, give it to Claude, and ask '**can you transcribe this and translate it into plain English?**'"*

Worked examples on the table — printed, A4. Pass them around.

1. **A Latin baptism entry** from a parish register. Photograph it through Claude. Ask: "What does this say, in English?" Read the answer aloud. "Patrick, son of Michael Walsh and Mary Murphy of Bandon parish, baptised 14 March 1865, sponsors John Walsh and Catherine Murphy."
2. **A page from the 1901 census.** Photograph it. Ask: "Who lived in this house?" Claude reads the columns — names, ages, occupations, religion, language.

3. **A gravestone photograph.** Same trick. Often these are weathered and unreadable to the eye but legible to Claude.

*“Three things to notice. **One:** Claude can read handwriting that you can’t. That’s the win. **Two:** it’s not always perfectly accurate — names get misread, dates get misread. So if a record matters, **double-check the date and the name** against another source. **Three:** the Latin trick isn’t just for genealogy. Old letters, old prayer cards, old documents — same trick.”*

1:05 — Where to look next (10 mins)

“Now you’ve got a starting tree with gaps in it. The next question is where do I look? Claude can help with this too — but it’s a research assistant, not a researcher. It tells you the door; you walk through it.

*Press the microphone. Say: ‘**I’m looking for the baptism record of Patrick Walsh, born around 1865 near Bandon in County Cork. Where would I look?’**”*

Read the answer aloud. Claude should suggest:

- **Irish Genealogy.ie** — free, the National Archives’ civil and parish register search.
- **National Library of Ireland parish registers** — free online, by parish.
- **Roots Ireland** — paid, but covers parishes the others miss.
- **The 1901 and 1911 censuses** — National Archives, free.
- **Griffith’s Valuation** (askaboutireland.ie) — for property and land, mid-1800s.

*“**Important.** Some of these things Claude might be confidently wrong about — a website might have changed, or a record collection might be smaller than it says. Always check by going to the actual website. Treat Claude’s suggestions as starting points, not gospel.”*

The bookmarked spare phone is here for anyone who wants to try Irish Genealogy.ie in the room.

1:15 — Writing the story (10 mins)

“Last bit. You can ask Claude to take everything you’ve told it — and everything it’s read from your photographs — and turn it into a one-page family story that a grandchild would actually read. Not a research paper. A story.

Press the microphone. Say: ‘Can you turn what we’ve talked about into a one-page family story I could give to my grandson, written warmly but factually, marking clearly anything we’re not sure of?’”

Read an example aloud. Notice that Claude marks uncertainty plainly: “family tradition says...”, “we believe but have not confirmed...”, “the parish is not yet known.”

“That last bit is the gold. Claude marking the difference between what’s known and what’s family lore. That’s what makes this a story your grandson can trust.”

1:25 — The awkward questions (5 mins)

“One last thing before we wrap. Family history is sometimes hard. Emigration that broke families. Children who went into mother and baby homes. Magdalene laundries. Workhouses. Names that changed for reasons people didn’t talk about. Illegitimacy. Suicide. The Famine itself.

Claude is a non-judgmental sounding board for these. You can ask it the questions you couldn’t ask your own mother. It won’t be shocked. It’ll help you understand the context, the records, the choices people had and didn’t have.

But — and this matters — what you find may be heavy. If a piece of family history hits you hard, talk to someone. Your GP, a friend, the parish priest if that’s your way. Don’t sit alone with something you’ve discovered. Ring me, even, if you can’t think who else.”

1:30 — Linger (30+ mins)

The genealogy conversations between attendees often run for an hour. Let them. The host and rovers stay available. **This is also when people ask for help on the harder family stories** — the things they didn’t want to bring up at the front of the room.

Booklet for Morning 4

Larger than the others — **12 pages instead of 8**, because there are more worked examples and more reference material.

1. Cover — *Morning 4: Your Family History, with a Research Assistant*
2. The four things Claude is good at — organise, read, suggest, write
3. The one thing it isn’t — a search engine for the records
4. Telling Claude what you already know — example dictation, example response
5. Reading old records — photographing, transcribing, translating

6. A worked example — Latin baptism entry, with Claude's translation
 7. A worked example — 1901 census page, with Claude's reading
 8. Where to look next — the five Irish sources, with web addresses
 9. Writing the story — one-page family history example
 10. The awkward questions — permission to ask, plus where to turn for support
 11. The next steps — joining a local genealogy society, the National Archives reading room
 12. Back cover / cheat sheet — and a thank-you, because it's the last morning
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Risks & what to do

Risk	What to do
Claude misreads a name in a record	Drill the double-check habit. Real research means cross-referencing.
Claude invents a record that doesn't exist	This happens. <i>"If a website Claude mentioned doesn't have what it said it had, it was wrong. Trust the website, not Claude."</i>
A learner discovers something distressing	Sit with them. Suggest someone to talk to. Follow up next week.
A learner wants to keep going past 90 mins	Good problem. Hosts and rovers stay if they can. Suggest meeting again.
The room divides into "lots of records" and "no records"	Pair them. The ones with records mentor the ones without.
Someone wants to use Claude on a sensitive document	Same as Morning 2 — cover the sensitive bits with a thumb.

After Morning 4 — the question that matters

This is the last morning of the planned four. Before everyone leaves:

*"These are the four mornings we planned. The question for you, before you go: **do you want to keep meeting?** Same time, every [week/fortnight]. Bring whatever question you've got. There's no curriculum any more — just tea, scones, and patient hands.*

Have a think on the way home. Tell me on Tuesday."

Most rooms will say yes. The pack for what comes after Morning 4 — call it **The Standing Morning** — is the next thing to write, but it's much smaller: no curriculum, just facilitation. That's a separate document.